CHAPTER 3

The Partition of Africa

In the late-nineteenth century a small group of European powers suddenly and dramatically became involved in a territorial Partition of Africa. Between 1880 and 1900 90 per cent of the territory of Africa was appropriated by a handful of European powers (see the map on page 45). Britain acquired nearly 5 million square miles of land, France gained 3.5 million and Germany, Belguim and Italy shared 2.5 million between them.

The 'Scramble for Africa' (as it was popularly termed) has been the subject of intense debate among historians ever since. In order to develop an understanding of this many-faceted topic it is necessary to build up a sound knowledge of the main events and of the different interpretations that have been advanced to explain them. It is also important to reach a conclusion about the reasons why each of the European powers (including Britain) became involved. To help in this task the chapter has been divided into three sections. The first looks at Britain's role in the major events of the Partition, the second explores the different interpretations of its causes, and the third offers an assessment of the reasons why each of the European powers took part.

1 Britain and the Partition of Africa

Before the Partition Britain's involvement in Africa was on a relatively small scale. She had no colonies at all in North or East Africa. In West Africa she controlled no more than several small coastal areas - Gambia, Sierra Leone (a free slave colony), Gold Coast Castle, and Lagos. In South Africa there was rather more of a presence: Cape Colony and Natal were formal colonies, and Britain claimed the right to control the foreign relations of the two 'Boer' republics, the Orange Free State and Transvaal. But this strong position was not seen as a spring-board for further acquisition, and in 1880 there were no plans to extend the British Empire in Africa. On the contrary, Gladstone, the Prime Minister, was committed to a policy of 'non-intervention' in colonial affairs. Yet in 1882 in a startling *volte face* he ordered the occupation of Egypt. This turned out to be the starting point of the Partition of Africa.

a) North Africa: The Occupation and Defence of Egypt

The Turkish (Ottoman) Empire had captured Egypt in 1517 and thereafter had expanded along the North African coast to Tripoli, Tunis, Algeria and Morocco. But by the late-nineteenth century the Ottoman Empire was in decline. This worried the British government

which feared that Ottoman possessions in North Africa would fall into the hands of rival European powers and thereby threaten British interests in the area. Lord Palmerston summed up British policy towards Egypt in 1860: 'we do not want to have Egypt. What we wish about Egypt is that it should be attached to the Turkish Empire, which is security against it belonging to another European power. We wish to trade with Egypt and travel through Egypt.'

The French took a different view. They encouraged Egypt to break away from the Ottoman Empire and French investors poured money into the country after 1850. The most dramatic example of French investment was a bold plan to construct the Suez Canal, which opened in 1869. It connected the Mediterranean with the Red Sea. It was designed by a Frenchman (Ferdinand de Lesseps), and built by tens of thousands of Egyptian labourers under the supervision of French engineers.

The completion of the Suez Canal led to a large influx of British investment. British banks offered the Egyptian government enormous loans which were used for economic development. Alexandria became a major port, over 1,000 miles of railway track were laid, arms were bought, and schools, roads and public buildings were built. Between 1863 and 1879 Egypt's foreign debt increased from £3 million to £100 million. The interest rate to be paid on it leapt in the same period from 7 per cent to 20 per cent. By 1875 Egypt had a 'debt crisis' which seemed likely to lead to the country's economic collapse. Although he still owed allegiance to the Sultan of Turkey, Ismail, the Egyptian ruler, in desperation requested the British and French governments to provide expert economic advice.

The British sent Stephen Cave, a British Treasury official, to investigate the financial state of Egypt. Cave believed Egypt's economic problems had two major causes.

> She suffers from the ignorance, dishonesty, waste and extravagance of the East, such as have brought her Suzerien [the Sultan of Turkey] to the verge of ruin, and at the same time from the vast expense caused by hasty and inconsiderate endeavours to adapt to civilisation.

Cave's report blamed Egypt's economic crisis on poor economic management and the swift rise in interest rates but concluded that,

> the resources of Egypt are sufficient, if properly managed, to meet her liabilities, but as all her available assets are pledged for the charges of existing loans, some fresh combination is necessary in order to fund at a moderate rate the present onerous floating debt ... A body of high class Europeans ... men like our Indian officials should take over the task of running the Egyptian economy.

In 1878 an Anglo-French rescue plan emerged. This was based on the ideas put forward in the Cave Report. The plan was simple. French government officials and British financial experts would take control of the Egyptian economy. The French would look after government expenditure; the British would raise revenue. This 'dual economic control' began in 1878 and ended in 1882. A strict set of emergency measures were implemented under the Anglo-French plan. The interest rate on the foreign loans was reduced to 5 per cent; the pay of the army, civil servants, and workmen employed by the government was cut; and a series of sales taxes (similar to VAT) were introduced on food and goods. The plan restored financial stability. But, in the process, it brought misery to the vast majority of the Egyptian people, and led to starvation in upper Egypt, increased unemployment, street rioting and, finally, a rebellion in the army.

In 1882 an Egyptian nationalist movement under the leadership of Arabi Pasha, a colonel in the Egyptian army, was on the verge of taking power. The nationalists wanted an end to Turkish dominance in government and Anglo-French control of the economy. By this stage law and order in Egypt had virtually collapsed. On 11 June a nationalist riot in Alexandria led to the death of 50 Europeans. This prompted the British government to order the formal occupation of Egypt. The Royal Navy bombarded, the British army invaded, and by October 1882 the rebellion had been crushed. Arabi Pasha was exiled to Ceylon, and Britain became 'the Government of Egypt'. Tewfik, Ismail's successor, was left in nominal charge but he was a mere figurehead. The British quickly ended Anglo-French 'dual control', much to the annoyance of the French, and stayed in Egypt until 1922.

The occupation effectively ended the long-held French hope of dominating an independent Egypt and led to bitter recriminations betweeen Britain and France which were to last for over 20 years. The cause of French outrage was not the occupation itself, which France had refused to join, but the British decision to rule the country on its own. This led to a French suspicion that Britain merely used the nationalist uprising as a cloak to hide its real desire to dominate Egypt and to freeze out France. The British attempt to allay French fears by ordering the withdrawal of Egyptian forces from the Sudan in 1884 ended in the siege at Kharthoum, the death of General Gordon, a British humiliation, and the withdrawal of British troops. In the late-1890s the British took revenge for Gordon's death by using armed force to annex the Sudan. This provoked more French anger and led to the 'Fashoda Incident' of 1898. This was a bungled attempt by a poorly equipped French expedition to capture the fort at Fashoda in western Sudan. The incident almost led to war between Britain and France, but the French government eventually backed down and agreed to the Sudan becoming a British 'sphere of influence'.

Advertisement for Pear's Soap (1887)

b) West Africa

The British government viewed West Africa with a great deal of detachment once the slave trade was outlawed in 1807. In 1865 a parliamentary select committee suggested that there should be no further colonial expansion in the region. The only reason Britain remained interested was due to the trade in palm oil which was used as an industrial lubricant and for the manufacture of soap - a thriving consumer growth industry in the late-nineteenth century. The leading British supplier of palm oil was George Goldie. He established a monopoly over the collection of palm oil on the River Niger through his United Africa Company (later renamed the Royal Niger Company). Goldie engaged in what the Foreign Office called 'creeping imperialism' by extending his economic interests inland from Accra. The British settlements of Sierra Leone and the Gold Coast were also expanded without government approval.

However, it was not Goldie or the British government who were the leading forces in the Partition of West Africa. France, Germany and King Leopold of the Belgians all played much more prominent roles. The French moved inland from Senegal and had ambitions to create a West African Empire. In 1882 the colonial agents of King Leopold arrived, signed treaties with several West African rulers, and set up the Congo Free State which developed a thriving rubber industry. Not surprisingly, the arrival of King Leopold alarmed the French who moved quickly inland from Gabon to create the French Congo. The British now became worried about the ambitions of the French and Leopold and signed a treaty with Portugal in February 1884 which recognised the ancient right of Portugal to the mouth of the Congo River. The whole situation grew even more complicated when Germany, led by Otto von Bismarck, seized Togoland and the Cameroons. The German Chancellor then shrewdly suggested that the European powers should settle their differences over territory peacefully by agreement. He suggested that this be done at a conference to be held in Berlin.

In December 1884 representatives of the major European powers met in Berlin in order to reach a settlement of the boundaries, trade and the rules of occupation in West Africa. The treaty they signed in 1885 agreed that there should be free trade in the Congo basin, recognised British economic interests on the Niger, and laid down ground rules for future annexation of territory in Africa. After the Berlin conference all a European power needed to do after grabbing land in Africa was to inform the other European powers that they were in 'effective occupation'. This arrangement speeded up the partition in the remainder of West Africa. The French took the majority of the available territory - which was mostly desert - and created French West Africa. The British gained a monopoly over the palm oil trade on the Niger River and created Nigeria. The Germans expanded in Togoland and the Cameroons. King Leopold gained recognition for his Congo Free State as a territory under his personal (rather than his country's) control.

c) East Africa

The partition of East Africa involved three powers: Britain, Germany and Italy. The major British interest in the region was trade with the island of Zanzibar. The British government had no plans to take formal control of any part of East Africa prior to the Partition. The leading 'man on the spot' and driving force behind British expansion in the region was Sir William McKinnon, a Scot who had built his fortune in the shipping trade. He believed - quite irrationally - that East Africa had enormous economic potential. The Imperial British East Africa Company was set up by McKinnon to attract investment to the area. Karl Peters, a German explorer, had similar plans. In 1884 he founded the rival German East Africa Company, signed treaties with local rulers in Tanganyika, and gained official backing for his efforts from Bismarck, the German Chancellor.

This intervention of Germany prompted the British government to give similar support to McKinnon. As a result, East Africa was divided by diplomatic agreement into British and German 'spheres of influence' between 1885 and 1895. Germany took control of Tanganyika. The British expanded to control Uganda, Kenya, Zanzibar, Pemba, and British Somaliland. At first, the British government left the administration of East Africa to the British East Africa Company. This proved beyond it. By 1895 the British government was in formal control of a largely unwanted East African empire.

Italy was the third European power to grab territory in East Africa by capturing Eritrea in 1882 and a large part of Somaliland in 1889. In 1896 Italy attacked Abbysinia (now Ethiopia), the last truly independent African state, and was defeated. This was the only occasion during the Partition on which an African state successfully resisted a European aggressor.

d) Southern Africa

The Partition of southern Africa was really a tale of Anglo-Boer rivalry and the ambitions of Cecil Rhodes, a British multi-millionaire who was the most famous 'man on the spot' of all. He arrived in South Africa in 1870, aged 17, full of ambition, and quickly made a fortune from diamond mining. He developed a 'big idea' for the expansion of the British Empire, as the following extract reveals:

> I contend that we are the first race of the world and that the more of the world we inhabit the better it is for the human race. I contend that every acre added to our territory means the birth of more of

> the English race who otherwise would not be brought into existence. Added to this, the absorption of the greater portion of the world under our rule simply means the end to all wars ... The furtherence of the British Empire, for bringing the whole of the uncivilised world under British rule, for the recovery of the United States, for making the Anglo-Saxon race but one Empire. What a dream! but yet it is possible. It is possible!

Standing in the way of Rhodes' 'impossible dream' were the independent Boer republics - the Transvaal and the Orange Free State. The Boers were white, Protestant, Dutch in origin, fiercely independent, and generally scornful of 'Liberal England'. They had originally settled on the southern tip of Africa but - as we saw earlier - they had moved north during the 'great trek' of the late 1830s to create independent states.

The Boers' insatiable desire for land created a great deal of antagonism, not only with Britain, but also with a large number of African tribal peoples. The most important were the Zulus, proud people, skilled in war and diplomacy. This enabled them to create what amounted to an anti-Boer coalition consisting of a large number of South African tribal peoples. The Transvaal became so frightened of the Zulu threat that they called on the British government - as what they saw as the lesser of two evils - to protect them. All this did was place the Zulu problem in the lap of the British government. In 1877 Britain took control of the Transvaal. The British then quickly issued an ultimatum to the Zulus, giving them two options. They could either disband their large army or face war with the 'mighty' British Empire. The Zulus chose war and were eventually defeated in 1879 after a valiant struggle.

The Zulu problem was no longer a factor in the way of British expansion in southern Africa but it was also no longer a restraint on the ambitions of the Boer republics. Shortly after the Zulu defeat the Transvaal asked Britain to restore its independence. The British refused. The Transvaal responded by attacking and defeating British forces at Majuba Hill in 1881. Following this set-back Gladstone's government agreed to restore control over domestic affairs to the Transvaal. The Transvaal government took this to mean that their country was fully independent. However, this was not Britain's understanding of the situation, as the wording of the agreements signed in 1882 and 1884 had left room for Britain to intervene in the domestic affairs of the Transvaal at some future date.

The discovery of gold and diamonds in Cape Colony and in the Boer republics was a 'mineral revolution' which transformed the economic fortunes of Cape Colony and the Transvaal. The Germans now began to take a greater interest in southern Africa for the first time. In 1884 they declared a protectorate over South West Africa (modern Namibia). The British responded by declaring a protectorate over Bechuanaland (modern Botswana).

In the early 1890s Cecil Rhodes, by now Prime Minister of Cape Colony, swiftly and ruthlessly expanded British rule. He captured the area that became known as Northern and Southern Rhodesia (modern Zambia and Zimbabwe) and made Nyasaland (modern Malawi) a British protectorate. By 1895 he was ready to deal with the Boer republics once and for all. He encouraged British settlers to work in his diamond mines in the Transvaal and to agitate for voting rights. The Transvaal government correctly saw this as a deliberate plot to undermine the country's independence. In 1895 Rhodes supported an armed coup aimed at seizing control of the Transvaal. He left the planning to Dr Jameson, an old friend who fancied himself a military genius but was more of a Colonel Blimp. Jameson thought a raiding party of 500 armed men would be enough to overthrow the Transvaal government. This was a major blunder. A planned uprising of the Uitlanders (as the Boers called the British mine workers) never materialised. The Boers had little difficulty in rounding up Jameson's small force.

The incident (known as the Jameson Raid) was a deep humilation for the British government. Joseph Chamberlain, the Colonial Secretary, and Lord Salisbury, the Prime Minister, were forced publicly to deny any knowledge of the raid (although it appears that Chamberlain was implicated). This left Cecil Rhodes to carry the can and he resigned. A broken man, he died in 1902.

In 1897, Sir Alfred Milner was appointed British High Commissioner for South Africa. Milner, a passionate imperialist, was supposedly appointed as a peacemaker in Southern Africa. But only days before his departure he was telling a friend that he was going to 'teach those bloody Boers a lesson'. Milner was to play a leading role in the events which led to the the Anglo-Boer War (often called the Boer War) of 1899-1902. This event is so important for understanding the development of the Empire between 1895 and 1914 it will discussed in greater depth in chapter 6. It was the last great act of British involvement in the Partition.

2 Interpretations

The Partition of Africa has produced a vast range of theories and interpretations and in a book of this size it would be impossible to do justice to them all. What can be done is to identify the three broad approaches into which they can be categorised. They can all be used to explain why each of the European powers became involved. A 'metropolitan' approach focuses on the motivations of each European power (metropole) and explains why each one joined in the Partition. 'Peripheral' approaches look at the problem from an African perspective and seek to show why each African region (periphery) was captured by a European power. An 'international relations' approach sets the Partition within a global framework. Each approach has been applied to explain the roles of Britain and the other European powers. However, no one approach has been generally accepted and the historical debate over the causes of the Partition remains a classic 'argument without end'.

a) Metropolitan Theories

i) J.A.Hobson: Overseas Investment

The best known metropolitan explanation was advanced in *Imperialism: A Study* (1902) by J.A. Hobson. This is a purely economic explanation, which views the Partition as a deliberately thought-out British policy designed by a shady élite of 'financiers, capital investors and unscrupulous politicians' who supported investment in new areas of the world rather than high wages and improved living conditions for the British worker. This led to a maldistribution of wealth. Hobson argued that while the rich had too much wealth and were encouraged to invest abroad, and the poor had so little in disposable income to spend, British industry could not expand. J.A. Hobson used economic statistics to support his interpretation. They do show a rapid increase in British overseas investment from £144 million in 1862 to £1,698 million in 1893. The Partition of Africa was, therefore, the British government supporting the aims of a small élite group of 'greedy capitalist' investors in Africa.

The impact Hobson made on the study of imperialism has been enormous. Yet his views have met with heavy criticism. D.K. Fieldhouse in *Economics and Empire* (1973) argues that Hobson failed to make a clear distinction about where British investment went in the late-nineteenth century. The largest proportion went to the settlement colonies, the USA, and Latin America - not tropical Africa. The importance Hobson assigned to the link between overseas investment and British involvement is debatable. In the case of Malaya investment only followed after annexation. The protection of the Suez canal and the route to India have also been shown to have been vitally important in determining British invervention in Egypt, East Africa and Southern Africa.

ii) Lenin: Crisis of Capitalism

Imperialism: The Highest Stage of Capitalism (1916) by V.I. Lenin was another purely economic explanation. Lenin was the leader of the Marxist-inspired Bolshevik Party and the leader of the 1917 Russian Revolution. He believed that 'a crisis in the capitalist economic system' in the late-nineteenth century was the main reason for European expansion in Africa. In his view, there were too many nations chasing too few markets. The free-trade era was abandoned by Britain's

l

economic rivals in favour of protectionism, cut-throat competition, and colonial rivalry. According to Lenin, European governments during the Partition were simply acting in the interests of 'finance capitalists' and 'monopoly companies' in their attempts to dominate sources of raw materials in Africa. He saw the European governments who agreed to expansion as the 'puppets' of capitalist businessmen. For Lenin, the Partition was the beginning of a more advanced stage of capitalist development which involved financiers and industrial producers attempting to gain a monopoly control over the supplies of raw materials for industrial production. Lenin believed that the only cure for imperialism was a revolution by the people. This would destroy capitalism and put an end to imperialism.

iii) Schumpeter: Crisis of Hereditary Élites

The Sociology of Imperialism (1951) by J.A. Schumpeter is a very important non-economic explanation. He defined imperialism as 'the objectless disposition on the part of a state to unlimited forcible expansion' and attacked the view that imperialism was linked to modern capitalism. Instead Schumpeter argued that the group who supported imperialism were old aristocractic hereditary élites who passed on ideas of imperial glory and aristocratic breeding and superiority from generation to generation.

It was 'old hereditary aristocratic élites', rather than capitalist businessmen or financiers, who Schumpeter believed were the leading forces behind the Partition of Africa. He thought that the aristocratic forces of Europe were seeking power and imperial glory abroad because they felt in danger of extinction from the rising business classes and rising working-class movements. Schumpeter predicted that the end of imperialism would only come when the power of the aristocracy was weakened and when governments followed a purely capitalist policy of free trade.

Schumpeter's theory which was essentially designed to attack the link of earlier theories between finance capitalism and imperialism has also aroused criticism. To begin with, the British aristocracy never fitted this concept; a great many of them were 'progressive' 'gentlemanly capitalists' who favoured peaceful economic expansion and social reform. Most British imperial administrators of the new tropical colonies of Africa were not drawn from the heriditary peerage but from the professional middle class. King Leopold, who should be typical of those Schumpeter had in mind, was actually interested in Africa as a suitable candidate for scientific exploration, technological advance and economic reward. The idea that the decline of the aristocracy would lead to the end of wars for military conquest simply does not fit in with the history of military conflict in the twentieth century.

iv) Eric Hobsbawm: Industry and Empire

Eric Hobsbawm, in *Industry and Empire* (1968), highlighted the importance of technological changes in Europe in the late-nineteenth century brought about by the industrial revolution. He described the Gatling Gun, the machine gun, the telegraph, the railway, and the steamship as the 'tools of Empire'. He believed that the technological advantage industry gave Europeans made the conquest of weak pre-industrial people easier and encouraged a new wave of imperialism. According to Hobsbawm, the Partition of Africa would not have occurred without the advances in technology that the industrial revolution produced.

v) Peter Cain and Tony Hopkins: 'Gentlemanly Capitalism'

The greatest challenge to Marxist interpretations - especially Lenin's view that the 'New Imperialism' was linked to the industrial process - is that put forward by P.J. Cain and A.G. Hopkins in *British Imperialism: Innovation and Expansion 1688-1914* (1993). They reject the link between industrialisation and imperial expansion and instead argue that a great deal of continuity existed in the development of British imperial expansion from 1688 to 1914. The commercial, professional and landed élites of London and the south-east, who had led imperial expansion in the eighteenth century helped to create a financial and service based economy focused on the City of London. This sector of the British economy expanded rapidly in the nineteenth century. As new 'gentlemen' emerged and thrived during this financial revolution in the City of London they joined forces with existing London élites to form a new 'Gentlemanly Capitalist' élite. The values of this dominant group were those taught at the more prestigious public schools such as Eton, Harrow, Rugby and Winchester and at Oxford and Cambridge Universities. They combined the life of the metropolis with a country estate, intermarried with the old artistocracy, and created 'old-boy networks' which dominated the leading echelons of power and influence within the British government and the Empire. Cain and Hopkins suggest that the British government, almost by instinct, rather than by any conspiratorial collaboration, put the needs of these 'gentlemanly capitalists' above those of 'socially and culturally inferior' northern industrialists who had come to prominance during the 'Industrial Revolution'. After 1870 the 'gentlemanly capitalists' invested heavily abroad and exerted pressure on the British government to defend their interests whenever they were threatened by European rivals and nationalist movements. Although the government claimed it was defending 'National Interests' during the Partition of Africa, those interests, argue Cain and Hopkins, had really become the interests of 'Gentlemanly Capitalism' in London and the south-east.

This is a bold, provocative and thought provoking interpretation.

They claim that every other theory of British imperial expansion - especially the Marxist emphasis on industry - is inadequate. By assigning primacy to financial and service sectors of the British economy in explaining British imperial expansion, they claim to have created a 'new framework for interpreting Britain's historic role as a world power'. The interpretation firmly puts 'economic impulses emanating from the metropole' back at the centre of discussion. It rejects the fashion of concentrating on changes at the periphery which had been so influential over imperial historians since the revisionist arguments of Gallagher and Robinson burst on to the scene in the 1950s, and spawned a wake of new studies in the 1960s and 1970s.

The work of Cain and Hopkins is something of a partial rehabilitation of the views of J.A. Hobson, in particular, his contention that overseas expansion in the late nineteenth century was driven by the needs of 'finance capitalists'. But Cain and Hopkins reject Hobson's idea of a well thought out conspiracy between government and the City of London. Instead they offer up the idea that the government's conception of 'National Interests' coincided - wittingly and unwittingly - with the interests of 'gentlemanly capitalist' financiers during the age of the so called 'New Imperialism'. The decision makers on colonial matters were basically the same sort of people who belonged to the same exclusive élite. The interpretation has the added attraction of providing a long-term explanation for the City of London's survival, the dominance of the south-east in the current British economy and the decline of northern industry and the Empire in the twentieth century.

It may be that once the dust of academic battle has settled the 'gentlemanly capitalist' will prove to be yet another example of bending the facts to fit a theory. Trying to isolate exactly how the 'gentlemanly capitalists' of the nineteenth century influenced government policy and explaining how the government wittingly and unwittingly supported their aims may prove an impossible task. A number of prominent historians have already raised doubts about the Cain and Hopkins interpretation. Andrew Porter, a leading imperial historian, recently claimed in the *Journal of Imperial and Commonwealth History* (1990) that their theory of 'gentlemanly capitalism' is too Anglo-centric in that it implies the development of British imperialism can be exclusively explained by reference to British governing élites and financial élites in the metropole while ignoring wider European and international issues. Martin Daunton in an article in the history journal *Past and Present* (1989) suggested that the term 'gentlemanly capitalism' does not adequately explain the nature of the British economy in the late-nineteenth century. He claimed that the role played by industrialists is not readily distinguishable from the activities of financial interests in the City of London.

Only time - and more research - will tell who is right. It may be that the city and industry were not as divorced from each other as Cain and

Hopkins imagine. The complexity of the government-business relationship may prove to have been oversimplified. Yet whatever the outcome of the debate over their theory, Cain and Hopkins' work is likely to retain a crucial importance within imperial history because it has focused attention on the nature of ruling élites in the City of London and on their relationship to imperial expansion in the late-nineteenth century. It may be that the strength of the link has been exaggerated but it already appears that previous studies did not take enough account of its real significance in the rise and fall of the British Empire. The work of Cain and Hopkins - now deeply influential - has boldly suggested that the empire was no simple 'handmaiden of industrial capitalism' but was rather the work of 'gentlemen' who managed 'men not machines' in London and the south-east. They have claimed that the British 'industrial revolution' was a phenomenon which had little impact on the course of British imperialism. True or false, this is an argument which no historian can possibly ignore.

b) Peripheral Theories

All the above are metropolitan theories and focus exclusively on European motivations. They look at the Partition from the perspective of European states and societies. They tell us very little about the role of Africa and its people, who are seemingly acted upon rather than being active in the process. Peripheral explanations suggest that the Partition cannot by explained solely by reference to European society. A peripheral theory is, therefore, one that gives due account to explaining how changes within the regions of Africa interacted with European desires for expansion. This means that such theories integrate the African dimension into the European framework.

i) Gallagher and Robinson

Gallagher and Robinson have been the pioneers of this approach. In their book *Africa and the Victorians: The Official Mind of Imperialism* (1961) they argued that British involvement in the Partition of Africa was not motivated by a 'new' desire by government to support British investment. Instead they suggested that 'the official mind' of British imperialism in Whitehall followed a consistent policy towards the Empire throughout the nineteenth century in seeking 'informal' control of trade wherever possible and only supporting formal rule when trade was threatened by civil disorder or the ambitions of a rival power.

According to Gallagher and Robinson the engine room of British intervention was not problems in Europe but was a purely 'local crisis' in Egypt. This dragged a reluctant British government into the problems of north Africa and led to Anglo-French rivalry which proved a vital contributor to the partition of west Africa and created tension in the

Sudan. Likewise they view British expansion in Southern Africa to be primarily due to worries over the rise of the Transvaal and Boer nationalism. They claim that throughout the duration of the Partition the British looked at their strategic role in the world and took little notice of business lobbies or public opinion before deciding to intervene. The crucially important part of Gallagher and Robinson's work is the importance they give to 'pull factors' in Africa which influenced Britain to become involved.

ii) The 'Men on the Spot' Factor

This interpretation, which has been advanced by a number of historians, emphasises the role played by 'men on the spot' in Africa who encouraged their governments to become involved. Rhodes in South Africa, Peters and McKinnon in East Africa, Goldie in West Africa and the role of French and Belgian colonial agents have all come under scrutiny. It has been claimed that these men had grand schemes of their own, that they worked with the local power brokers to get them under way, and that they then gained the support of their governments to complete the process.

iii) African Nationalism

African historians have undertaken important research into the role played by Africans during the Partition. They have shown how African nationalism was crucial in Egypt, the Sudan, Abyssinia and in southern Africa; how African rulers, states and merchants collaborated with European powers; and how other African tribes such as the Zulus (in South Africa), the Ashanti (in the Gold Coast) and the Mashona (in Southern Rhodesia) fought bravely to retain their independence. It has also been shown how African leaders sought agreements with different European powers. A good example of how this tribal diplomacy worked can be be found in a letter from King Bell and King Acqua to Gladstone.

> Dear Mr. Gladstone,
>
> We both your servants have met this afternoon to write you these few lines of writing trusting it may find you in a good state of health as it leaves us at present. As we heard you are the chief man in the House of Commons, so we may write to tell you that we want to be under Her Majesty's control. We want our country to be governed by the British government. We are tired of governing this country ourselves, every dispute leads to war, and often great loss of lives, so we think it is best thing to give up the country to you British men with no doubt will bring peace, civilisation and Christianity in the country. Do for mercy's sake please lay our request before the queen and to the rulers of the British Government. Do, sir, for

Government. Do, sir, for mercy sake, please assist us in this important undertaking. We heard that you are a good man, so we hope that you will do all you can in you power to see that our request is granted. We are quite willing to abolish all heathen customs. No doubt god will bless you for putting a light in our country. Please to send us an answer as quick as you can.

King Bell and King Acqua
of the Cameroons River, West Africa
6 November 1881

In general the pleas of African leaders fell on deaf ears. For example, Gladstone did not even reply to this request, and at the Berlin Conference the British agreed to the German conquest of the Cameroons.

Clearly, peripheral explanations do provide a balance to metropolitan approaches which claim the partition can only be explained by the actions of European capitalists, financiers, governments, industry and aristocrats. As a reaction against these approaches peripheral theory shows that social, economic and political factors in Africa played a much greater role within the process than has often been recognised. Most metropolitan theories assume that all the decisions relating to imperialism were made by a very few Europeans located in the major capitalist nations. It is therefore only to be expected that many older accounts of imperial history view the Partition in terms of what Europeans did, how they did it, and why they did it - in fact, as a mere 'sideshow' to events in Europe. This does no justice to the importance of Africans in the process.

c) International Relations Theories

Another development in the study of imperialism has been the use of international relations theories to explain the Partition. These approaches set the Partition of Africa within a global framework.

i) A.J.P. Taylor: The Primacy of Political and Diplomatic Factors

A.J.P. Taylor in *The Struggle for Mastery in Europe* (1954) gave primacy to the political and diplomatic aims of the leading European powers. Taylor believed that the Partition was due to changes in European power politics and society. He suggested that the victory of Germany in the Franco-Prussian War of 1871 unhinged the balance of power in Europe, created a deadlock in European politics, and encouraged the growth of militant nationalism, which found expression in overseas expansion.

Taylor described Europe after 1870 as 'an armed camp' with the balance of power being so delicately poised that any small conflict within

the continent was likely to produce war. He maintained that in these circumstances the partition of Africa provided a safe arena for European competition for expansion without the risk of producing a European war. His view was that the Partition constituted a totally unplanned and irrational extension to Africa of 'the struggle for mastery in Europe'.

D.K. Fieldhouse and a number of other diplomatic historians once favoured this argument. But in his later work, such as *Economics and Empire* (1973), Fieldhouse placed far greater emphasis on economic problems in Africa which he believed pulled the European powers into the region.

ii) Paul Kennedy: The Rise and Fall of Great Powers

A broader international relations approach which looks beyond Europe is put forward by Paul Kennedy in *The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers* (1988). The book examines the Partition within the context (or grand sweep) of the rise and fall of the major powers of world history. Kennedy suggests that the industrial revolution made Britain the most dominant power in the world between 1815 and 1870. During this period Britain created a new model of great power status, based on free trade, industry, naval power, investment, and colonies. In Kennedy's view, the Partition of Africa happened because other European powers sought to emulate the British path to great power status. As European powers expanded in Africa, the British responded and seized colonies. He therefore concludes that British involvement was driven by a desire to defend her dominance of international trade and imperial rule.

This argument is attractive as it looks at the issue within a global framework and combines evidence from metropolitan and peripheral approaches. It also has the advantage of explaining the motivations of all the European powers. It seems likely that the 'international relations' approach will feature strongly in the future debate over the causes of the Partition of Africa.

3 Britain, the European Powers and the Partition: An Assessment

It is clear that the mountain of interpretations which have been put forward to explain the Partition of Africa has produced no consensus on why Britain and the other European powers became involved. It seems that the reasons for the participation are complex and do not lend themselves to a simple explanation. However, it does seem worthwhile attempting a brief survey of the probable motives of each of the European powers which joined in the Partition.

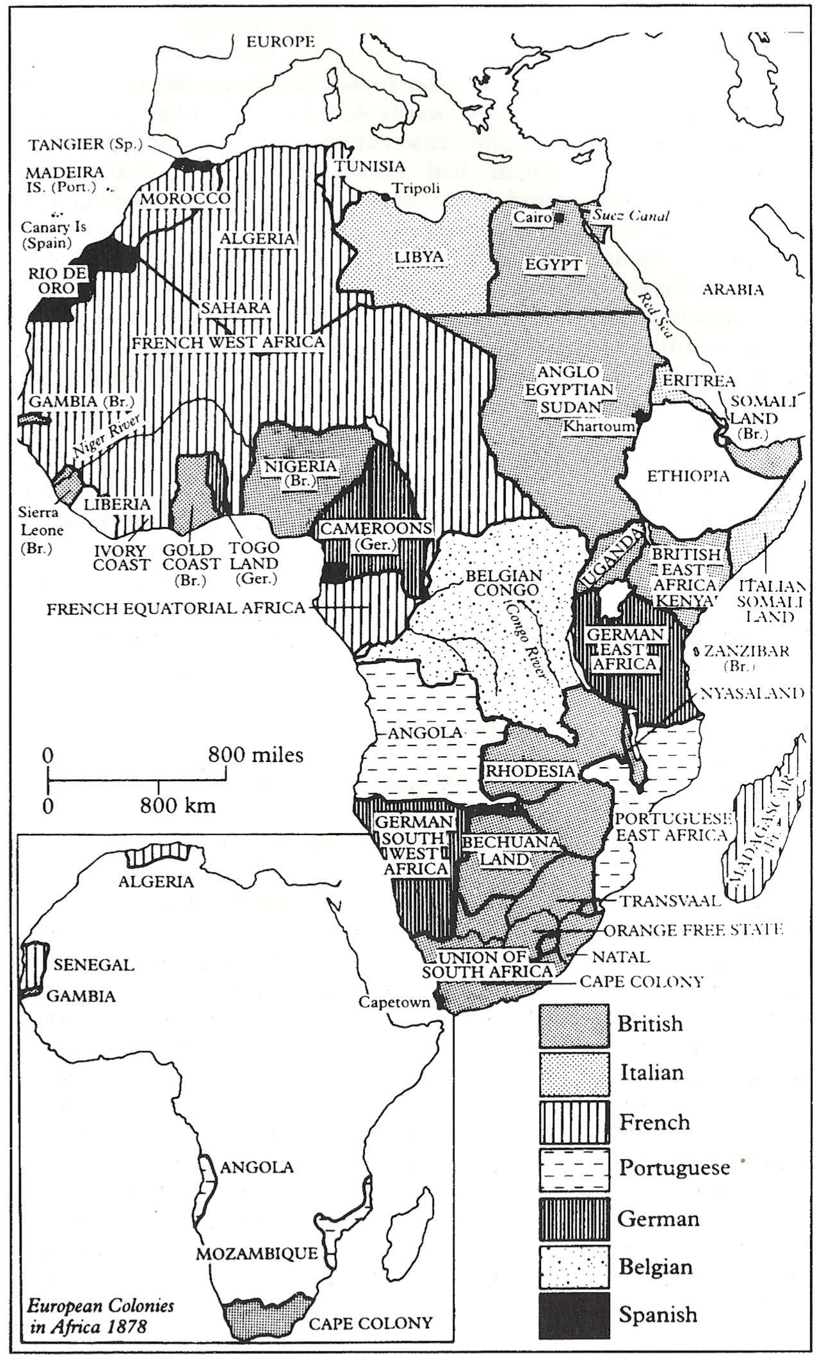
a) Britain

The argument that Britain's reasons for becoming involved in the Partition of Africa were a mixture of power politics and economic necessity appears impossible to deny. This view fits most British actions during the Partition. For example, it particularly seems to make sense of the events that led up to the occupation of Egypt. It was a fear that the Suez Canal might fall into the hands of a rival power which lay behind much of what was done. Of course, all historians would agree with the assessment thus far. The issue that remains unresolved, and a matter of major controversy, is the balance between political and economic motives. Perhaps the judgement whether Britain acted more from a desire to protect and/or increase her power than from a wish to protect and/or add to her wealth will always have to be made depending on the observer's values and prejudices. Certainly there is plenty of evidence to support both points of view.

Any argument which sees the British government as a 'reluctant' participant in the Partition is persuasive. The slow and deliberate way in which the British government reacted both to events in Africa and to the activities of rival European powers during the early stages of the Partition certainly adds weight to this interpretation. However, it must be remembered that there was never any doubt that the vast growth of British investment in north and southern Africa was going to be protected, and therefore too much should not be read into the reluctance. The Victorian 'frame of mind' was never passionate, always appeared reluctant, but in practice never flinched from defending British economic interests whenever and wherever they were felt to be threatened.

b) Germany

In the case of Germany we see a greater interest in purely political objectives. Germany was determined to become the dominant European power and colonial issues were very much used to further this end. In particular, up to 1890 while Otto von Bismarck was Chancellor, German aims were clearly centred on Europe. The case for arguing that Bismarck used colonial problems for political ends is persuasive. He said that, 'My map of Africa is in Europe. Here lies Russia and here lies France, that is my map of Africa'. In January 1889 he said in a Reichstag speech that he viewed colonial expansion with 'the gravest apprehension' and insisted that in Africa Germany should proceed 'slowly and in agreement with England'. Bismarck also used colonial victories for the political objective of winning elections. He won the 1884 German election on the wave of euphoria produced by his colonial triumph in West Africa.



The Partition of Africa 1878 and 1914

c) France

France's motives are more difficult to assess because the country was divided over what the policy towards Africa ought to be. There were pro-imperialists who advocated colonial expansion - in order to restore the national pride which had been dented by defeat in the Franco-Prussian War - and there were anti-imperialists who felt that the Partition was an unwelcome diversion from the more pressing need to take revenge against Germany. Politicians of both persuasions were in power at different times during the Partition, hence a lack of consistency in the policies that were followed. For example, anti-imperialists missed the opportunity of joining Britain in the occupation of Egypt in 1882, while pro-imperialists almost led France into a war with Britain over the Sudan in 1898.

However, the French public as a whole never displayed any great enthusiasm for imperialism. In fact, when French governments followed imperial policies not in tune with public opinion they lost power. This happened in 1881 over Tunis in North Africa and in 1885 over Tonkin in Indo-China. There were few votes to be gained by being jingoistic in France. It is true that the French did see economic benefits to be gained in North Africa, but there is no evidence of a 'capitalist plot'. The view that France became involved in the Partition for reasons of dented national pride remains the most attractive.

d) The Minor European Powers

Of the remaining European participants in the Partition, the activities of Belgium and King Leopold have attracted the most attention. King Leopold emerges as the only European statesmen with a clear plan to acquire territory in Africa. Yet he had little backing from the Belgian government for his expansionist policy, and he was forced to play a remarkably personal role.

Leopold had dreamed of a Belgian colonial empire since the 1860s. He became interested in acquiring territory after hearing the reports of the British explorers David Livingstone and Verney Lovett Cameron. In 1876 he invited a distinguished group of geographers and explorers to Brussels to discuss the potential of Africa and out of this came the International Africa Association, which claimed to bring the benefits of 'science and civilisation' to Africa. Lord Rosebery, the Foreign Secretary, said he would be more able to accept Leopold's sincerity 'if he looked a little less like Fagin' (a villainous character in Dickens' novel, *Oliver Twist*). King Leopold actually behaved like Fagin. He ran the Congo purely for economic gain and his agents treated the Africans who worked in the Congo rubber industry with merciless barbarity. This cruel exploitation was the biggest scandal of the Partition of Africa and was roundly condemned by the Belgian parliament.

It seems clear that Italy was largely motivated by a desire for enhanced international status. Italians also felt there were possible economic benefits in Africa. There were some successes but, of course, the Italian bid for colonies ended in a national humiliation when they were defeated by the Abyssinians at the battle of Adowa in 1896.

The roles of Portugal and Spain were relatively insignificant as both nations simply attempted to preserve their existing interests. Therefore the part they played in the Partition was almost completely defensive, and seems to have been driven by a desire to retain some symbol of the countries' glorious pasts.

Making Notes on *'The Partition of Africa'*

This chapter covers an extremly popular examination topic in both British and European courses. You would therefore be well advised to make fairly detailed notes.

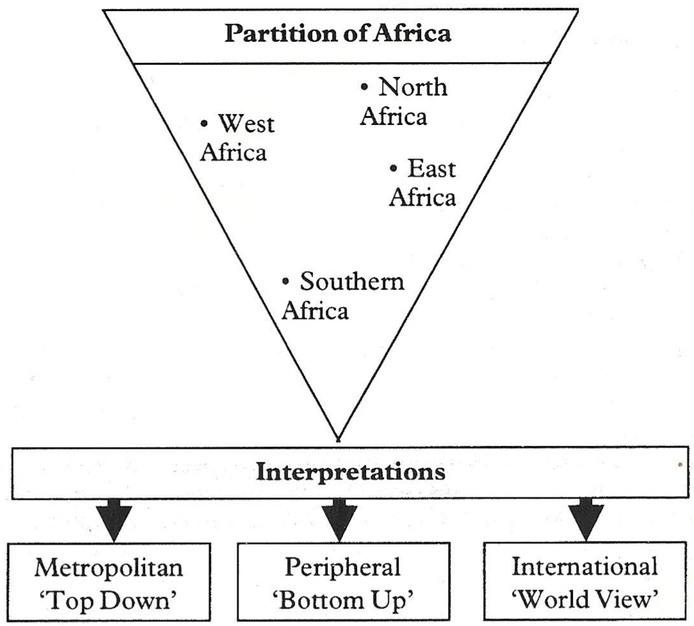
You need to have three aims at the start of your note-making:

i) To gain a clear grasp of the key events of the Partition,

ii) To build up an understanding of the various interpretations, and

iii) To acquire an appreciation of why each of the European powers played the part it did in the Partition.

You may find that the following headings and questions will provide a suitable structure for your note-making.



Summary - The Partition of Africa